The Sūtra of the Eight Lights, the Clear and Vast Dharma of the Buddha

Toh 1067 · Derge Kangyur

སངས་རྒྱས་ཀྱི་ཆོས་གསལ་ཞེའི་ཡངས་པ་སྣང་བར་བྱེད་ཅེས་བ་བྱའོ་མིད་ོ

The Sūtra of the Eight Lights, whose full title is The Sūtra Called the Eight Lights, the Clear and Vast Dharma of the Buddha, and whose Tibetan title is Sangyé kyi Chö Selzhing Yangpa Nanggyé, is Toh 1067 in the Kangyur, where it is placed in the collection of dhāraṇī texts; it gives no Sanskrit title, since it derives from a scripture composed in Chinese, the Sūtra of the Eight Yang of Heaven and Earth. In it the bodhisattva Unimpeded asks the Buddha why the beings of this world suffer so much, and the Buddha teaches that reading the Eight Lights three times brings protection and good fortune at birth, marriage, the building of a house, travel, and funerals, wards off illness, evil omens, and harmful spirits, and frees parents and the dead from the lower realms. Addressing popular concerns with auspicious days, geomancy, and astrological spirits, it declares that all days are auspicious, and it includes a short mantra offered by eight bodhisattvas. Toward its end it explains its own title through the eight consciousnesses, teaching that the senses and their objects are empty, that light means clear knowing, and that eight means discerning distinctions.

The Sūtra Called the Eight Lights, the Clear and Vast Dharma of the Buddha. In one section.

Homage to all the buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One Śākyamuni was dwelling in a many-storied palace of jewels. The bodhisattvas of the ten directions, the eight classes of gods and spirits, and others made offerings to the Blessed One and praised him. Then, from among the great assembly, the bodhisattva Unimpeded joined his palms and addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, the sentient beings of Jambudvīpa have been circling in the cycle of birth and death since beginningless time. Among them, those who have understanding are few, and those without understanding are many. Those who keep moral discipline are few, and those who do not keep moral discipline are many. The diligent are few, and the lax and distracted are many. The long-lived are few, and the short-lived are many. Those who have wealth are few, and those of meager means are many. The happy are few, and those who suffer are many. The decrees and harsh measures of those above are

issued again and again, while those below never know release from the eight sufferings. Of what is not the Dharma they say, 'It is.' Because of their wrong views, many beings are short-lived and perish in sudden calamities. Please grant that they may be freed from their many sufferings and that their hardships may be averted."

The Blessed One declared: "Excellent, excellent, Unimpeded! Bodhisattva, what you have asked for the benefit of many beings and out of compassion I shall explain; listen! Many buddhas of the past have also taught it. Now I too shall teach it; listen! The buddhas of the future will surely teach it as well.

"Moreover, among sentient beings there is none nobler than humans. Yet even when they obtain a human body, they cannot practice the splendor of goodness, and they go against the right view. Deceivers, asuras, and the like, having committed many kinds of evil, if they take these Eight Lights as their solemn commitment and recite them, will be freed from all their evil and non-virtuous karma. Their lives will lengthen, sudden calamity will not strike them, and they will become endowed with good qualities. And when their lives are exhausted, they will attain the fruit of an arhat.

"Some people, because they do not practice the good Dharma, meet with many illnesses and all kinds of evil omens. If, in their great suffering, they meet a spiritual friend and these Eight Lights are read three times, even their many illnesses will be healed, and the various evil omens will not menace them. Even the evil of the five acts of immediate retribution will be purified. They will also obtain loving-kindness, compassion, joy, and equanimity, and the eighteen unshared qualities of a buddha.

"Whoever, man or woman alike, intends at some time to break ground for a building, if they read this text of the Eight Lights three times, then whether they raise walls, make doorways, dig wells, set up hearths, or set up mortars and mills, whether they set up mills or build storehouses and livestock pens, the gods of the directions and intermediate directions, east, west, south, and north, the planets, the inauspicious lunar mansions, the Enemy, the Field Fortune, the Yellow One like a Leopard's Tail, the fierce earth spirits, the gods of the five kinds of earth, the Azure Dragon, the White Tiger, the Vermilion Bird, the Black Tortoise, those who carry out all the deeds that are hidden by the six divination charts and may not be spoken of, and also the Cutter of All, the Fierce One, the Doer of Good and Ill, the Full, the Level, the Permanent, the One Who Holds as One, the Divided, the Listener, the Accomplished, the

Gatherer, the Lord of the Earth, the Black One, the Near Black One, the gods, the nāgas, and all ghosts and seizing spirits will give way and flee.

"For all the farming there is to do, and whether one goes a short way or travels anywhere at all, if one reads the Eight Lights three times, there will be no misfortune at home or abroad, and one will soon return. Children and grandchildren will show great respect to their parents, and there will be wealth and power, happiness and well-being. Even if one goes into the wilderness or among beasts of prey, the nāgas and the beasts of prey will give way and flee of their own accord. Even if one is caught up in a dispute or taken prisoner, one will soon be freed of one's own accord. Even if one goes into fire, the fire will not harm one; even if one goes into water, the water will not harm one. Neither weapons nor enemies will harm one. Poisons, too, will turn into food like nectar, and poison will not harm one.

"If any son or daughter, out of fear that their parents bear evil deeds, reads this text of the Eight Lights three times, the parents will be freed from the Avīci hell and will be born in the higher realms. Wherever this text of the Eight Lights is kept, the eight bodhisattvas, Brahmā, Śakra (Indra), the Four Great Kings, the gods, nāgas, yakṣas, and others adorn it with all kinds of offerings and worship it. If one reads this Dharma sūtra and explains it in full, it is to be seen as the body of the Tathāgata.

"The eye discerns various forms. Form itself is empty; emptiness itself is form. The ear hears various sounds. Sound itself is empty; emptiness itself is sound. The nose senses various smells. Smell itself is empty; emptiness itself is smell. The tongue discerns various tastes. Taste itself is empty; emptiness itself is taste. The body discerns various tangible objects. The tangible itself is empty; emptiness itself is the tangible. Wisdom is empty; emptiness, too, is wisdom."

Then the bodhisattva Unimpeded said this to the Blessed One: "In a single human life there is nothing more difficult than being born and dying. When one is born, one is born without choosing the day; when one dies, one dies without choosing the day. Yet when, after a death, the funeral rites are performed, if they are carried out without choosing a good or bad time, many misfortunes arise: the family line is cut off, poverty and want set in, and many disputes arise. Why does this happen?" When he had asked this, the Blessed One declared: "It is most excellent that you have asked this for the sake of beings who perform funeral rites.

"Moreover, heaven and earth are both auspicious, and the sun and moon are both good and bright. The bodhisattva king of humans is exceedingly loving and greatly compassionate, and looks upon all sentient beings equally, as on an only child. When he teaches the good customs of the land, people invoke and make offerings to the non-virtuous gods and spirits and to all the hungry ghosts, and so the various kinds of ghosts and seizing spirits, being served good and tasty human food, grow attached, and all kinds of suffering befall people. They have no faith in the holy Dharma; they make offerings of living beings in the cult of ghosts and seizing spirits, and they put their faith in tearing apart and eating the three red things. Because they see and act wrongly, the family line is cut off, poverty and want set in, and all kinds of misfortune arise.

"When a son or daughter is about to be born, if one reads the Eight Lights three times, the birth will be easy, and the child will be intelligent and endowed with fine marks; kinnaras and the like will not steal its vitality, and sudden calamity will not cause it to die. And when someone's time has come and they die, if one reads the Eight Lights three times, not a single kind of harm will arise afterward.

All days are auspicious;
All lunar mansions are good;
All arhats have exhausted the defilements;
All buddhas have great miraculous power.

"As for the funeral rites, if, with whatever provisions are at hand and whenever one is able, one reads the Eight Lights three times and then performs the rites, the deceased too will be born in the higher realms, and the children, grandchildren, and relatives will also become rich and powerful. For the tomb as well, there is no need to inquire about and examine east, south, west, and north: wherever the ground is pleasant and wherever people are glad, there the noble gods are glad too. If one reads the dharma three times and builds the tomb there, there will never be any misfortune; the household will be rich, its people will flourish, and all will be auspicious."

Then the Blessed One spoke these verses:

The day one seeks is most auspicious;
The day of burial is wholly good.
If this is read for the living and the dead,
Great merit will be gained.

"If one reads this text and performs the funeral rites, there will be wealth and power for a thousand years."

At that time, as many as seventy-seven thousand of the multitude of beings had their minds liberated and were happy at heart, and they obtained and practiced what is called the dustless eye of Dharma.

Then it was asked again: "Blessed One, when people marry, they first consider whether the match is compatible or not, and only afterward choose a day and then marry. Yet after marrying, those who are rich and powerful are few, and those who are poor and destitute are many. They are alike in holding wrong views, so why are there differences? Blessed One, please explain this for the multitude."

Then the Blessed One declared: "Heaven is the husband and earth the wife; the moon is male and the sun is female. When heaven and earth come together, all plants and trees grow. When the sun and moon revolve in turn, the four seasons and the eight seasonal junctures become manifest. When fire and water meet, all that grows comes forth in its season. When man and woman are in harmony and united, the children and grandchildren are born wise. Those who practice virtue and obtain a human body are like the dust that clings to a fingernail; those who practice non-virtue and are born in great numbers as hungry ghosts, animals, and hell beings are as many as the earth itself. If, at the time of marrying and at the time of giving birth, one reads the Eight Lights three times, its roots of virtue will generate one another, so that the household's standing will be high, its people powerful, its children and grandchildren thriving, wise, and greatly respectful, and it will be endowed with the splendor of goodness."

Then these bodhisattvas rose, whose names were the bodhisattva Unsurpassed, the bodhisattva Virtuous Friend, the bodhisattva Pure Eyes, the bodhisattva Mountain Glory, the bodhisattva Great Refuge, the bodhisattva Wheel King, the bodhisattva Pure of Stains, and the bodhisattva Harmonious Union. These eight said to the Blessed One: "We shall recite and present the essence of mantra that we heard from the buddhas, the blessed ones of the past; please bless it. oṃ ākani nikani āpīla mandhale mandhale svāhā. Should there be anyone who turns away from or transgresses the word of the Blessed One and this secret mantra, his head will split into seven pieces and the limbs of his body will be burned."

Again the bodhisattva Unimpeded said this to the Blessed One: "Why is this text called the Eight Lights?"

The Blessed One declared: "'Light' means clear knowing; 'eight' means discerning distinctions. The principle of the Mahāyāna sūtra that does what is to be done is illumined and known; because the causes and conditions of consciousness are empty of one another, it exists as letters and as Dharma, and so its name is the Text of the Eight Lights. The eye is the consciousness of form; the ear is the consciousness of sound; the nose is the consciousness of smell; the tongue is the consciousness of taste; the body is the consciousness of the tangible; mentation is the consciousness that discerns distinctions. That which knows the preceding six and knows them as connected is not separate from them; together with the all-base consciousness, they make eight. The root and the substance of the eight consciousnesses are empty and at peace. When one focuses on that, the eye consciousness is the bodhisattva of light; the ear consciousness is the bodhisattva of resounding sound; the nose is the bodhisattva who discerns the various smells; the tongue is the bodhisattva who examines tastes; the body is Vairocana, who discerns smooth and rough. Vairocana is supreme: Pure Vairocana, Mirror-like Vairocana, Light Vairocana, and mentation, which knows perfectly and is unmoving. The mind is the expanse of focus. The all-base consciousness is the great liberation of wisdom; it is the Dharma of the Buddha. Its name is the Treasury of Emptiness.

"If some person builds a new house or moves into a new house and wishes for good fortune, if they read the Eight Lights three times, good fortune will come. If one writes out the Eight Lights, reads it, or recites it from memory, one will be endowed with an immeasurable aggregate of merit."

When this Dharma sūtra was taught, monks, nuns, laymen, laywomen, and sixty-six thousand people obtained the dhāraṇī of the undefiled Dharma, and the earth shook in six ways.

Countless gods, nāgas, asuras, garuḍas, kinnaras, mahoragas, yakṣas, humans, nonhumans, and others obtained the pure eye of Dharma, and they practiced the Dharma of bodhisattvas. Eighty-one thousand ordinary beings obtained the fruit of an arhat. When the Blessed One had spoken thus, the bodhisattva Unsurpassed and all the others rejoiced at what the Blessed One had said and praised it highly.

This completes the noble Mahāyāna sūtra called the Eight Lights.

Translator's Notes

• This sūtra corresponds to the Chinese Sūtra of the Eight Yang of Heaven and Earth, in which the bodhisattva who questions the Buddha is Wu'ai, "Unobstructed"; the Tibetan thogs pa med pa is therefore translated as Unimpeded rather than given an Indian form. The long list of spirits renders Chinese calendrical and geomantic deities, among them the four directional animals, the taboos of the six jia days (here the six gab rtse, rendered "divination charts"), and the twelve day-officers (the Cutter, the Full, the Level and so on); these names are translated literally. The phrase pho smos mtshungs is read as pho mo mtshungs, "men and women alike." In the sentence on the five acts of immediate retribution the Tibetan has 'byung, "will arise," which contradicts the list of benefits; it is read as 'byang, "will be purified."
• The names of the eight bodhisattvas, like that of Unimpeded, are translated, since this sūtra derives from a Chinese original and Indian forms for them cannot be established. Kun pos, "invoke all," is read as kun bos. Ma chad pa, something that is sited and built, is taken as the tomb, matching the passage on burial sites in the Chinese version. Stangs and 'byal are taken as the Old Tibetan words for husband and wife. The "three red things" (dmar gsum) are apparently the bloody offerings of animal sacrifice.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.